FROM BIBI TO SULTAN

In the first forty years of Akbar's reign, the Mughal Empire had grown to a size which had been inconceivable when the Padshah took over as a distracted thirteen-year-old boy in 1556. By 1596, according to Abu'l Fazl, the kingdom was divided into sixteen subahs, each subah as large as a European kingdom of the same time and generating a revenue of over nine crore rupees. Historian George Keene has summarized Abu'l Fazl's description succinctly: In the east were Bengal and Orissa, with the capital at Gaur. Equally large were the provinces of Allahabad and Awadh while the province of Agra was smaller but strategically important, with the capital city at Agra. Malwa province had its capital at Mandu and Gujarat province brought important access to the sea. Ajmer, though a large province, was poorer than the others, while Delhi and Lahore brought in an equal share of revenue.

Four additional subahs were Multan, Tattah, Kashmir, and Kabul. The fifth, Khandesh, was yet to be incorporated for a warrior queen stood in the way of Akbar's ambition.

Charged by his father to subdue the Deccan in 1595, Murad had fetched up in Ahmadnagar to remind the heirs of the ungrateful Nizam Shah of their duties of allegiance to the Padshah Akbar. There he found a woman in charge of a chaotic and violently simmering group of suspicious and jealous noblemen, soldiers, and slaves. This was Chand Bibi, who had been married to Ali Adil Shah of Bijapur in 1564, as part of a rash of alliances made to bind the five sultanates of the Deccan in common cause against the kingdom of Vijayanagar. Vijayanagar had been defeated at the Battle of Talikota in 1565 but after that the sultanates resumed bickering and quarrelling with one another. In 1580, Ali Adil Shah had been put to death and Chand Bibi returned to Ahmadnagar, the city of her birth.

Chand Bibi was the daughter of Hussain Nizam Shah of Ahmadnagar and appeared to have enjoyed much freedom in her upbringing and in her marriage to Ali Adil Shah. She has been depicted in miniature paintings playing polo, riding horses, and hawking, always unveiled. She was a consummate diplomat and strategist, ruling Bijapur as regent after the death